

CSCI 3921W - Social, Legal, and Ethical Issues in Computing

Ethics Analysis Exercise

Suppose it is obvious that someone in need should be helped. A utilitarian (consequentialist) will point to the fact that the consequences of doing so will maximize well-being, a deontologist to the fact that, in doing so the agent will be acting in accordance with a moral rule such as “Do unto others as you would be done by” and a virtue ethicist to the fact that helping the person would be charitable or benevolent.” – [Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy](#)

Group Activity

Each group will analyze the same technology from different ethics perspectives/frameworks.

In your group, answer the questions under your assigned framework. Be prepared to share your analysis with the class.

Technology: **ONLINE LEARNING WITH FACIAL EMOTION ANALYSIS**

Consequentialism

1. Who will be affected? Consider individuals and groups of people (identify stakeholders)
2. Who might use this product that we didn't expect to use it, or for purposes we didn't initially intend? (expand stakeholders)
3. What are the benefits of this technology?
4. What are the negative side effects or risks of this technology?
5. Who receives the benefits of this technology, and who bears the brunt of the negative side effects or risks?

6. Would a different technological design or abstaining from the technology altogether yield a better overall outcome for society?

Deontology/Contractualism

1. How does this technology sustain or violate fundamental human rights? (Some human rights: privacy, informed consent, bodily autonomy, or dignity)? You can consult the [UN's Universal Declaration of Human Rights](#) for a more complete list
2. How does this technology sustain or violate other societal norms and rules?

Virtue Ethics

1. How does this technology cultivate positive human traits (like empathy, patience, honesty, and wisdom)?
2. How does this technology feed vices (like impatience, arrogance, superficiality, or cruelty)?
3. How does this technology support genuine human excellence and connection?
4. How does this technology elevate or degrade our capacity for deep thought, physical presence, and self-reliance? (add here any other relevant virtues)

References

[An Ethical Toolkit for Engineering/Design Practice](#)

[Ethics & Algorithms Toolkit: A risk management framework for governments \(and other people too!\)](#)

[Unesco's Ethical Impact Assessment](#)